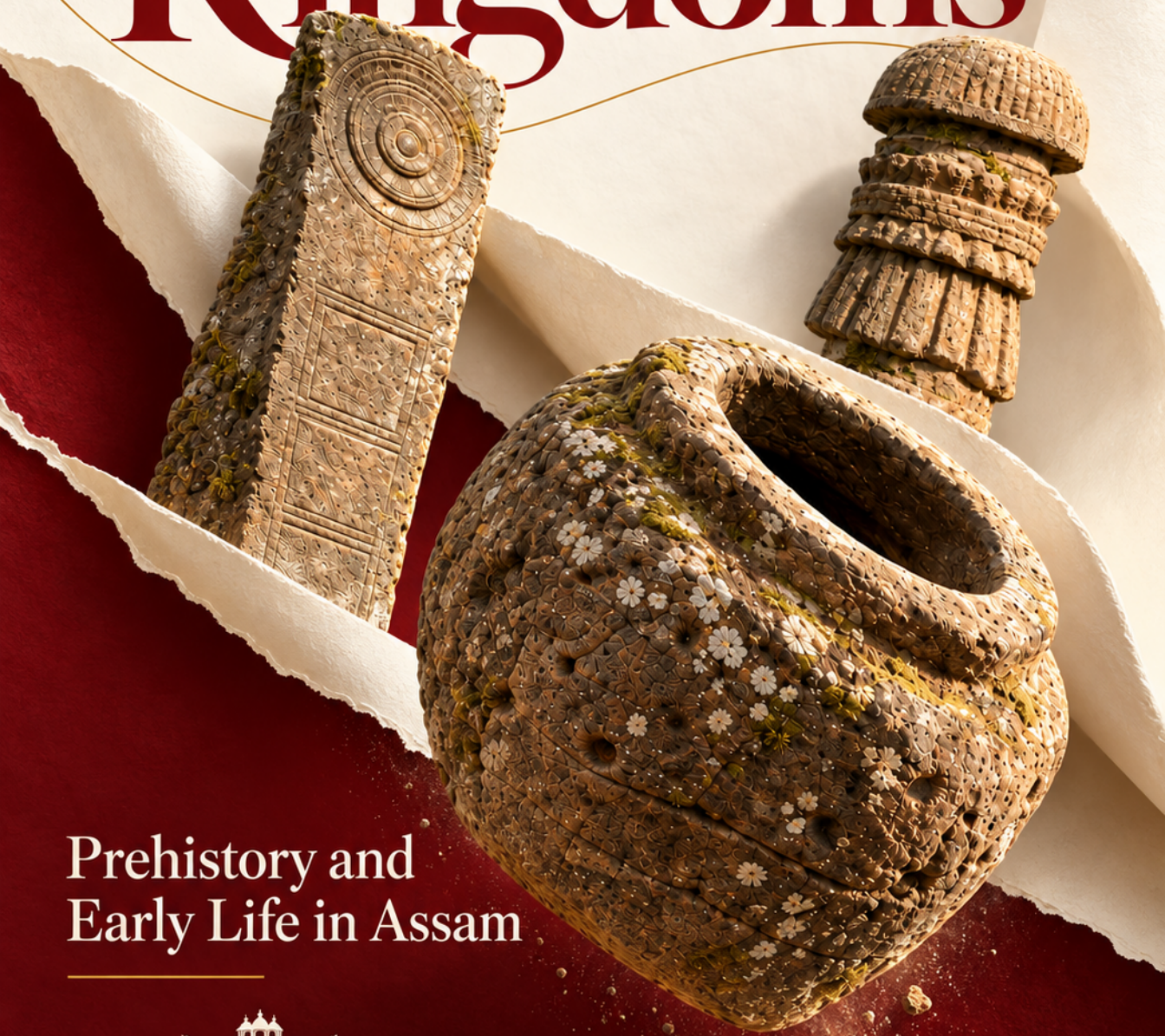
ASSAM HISTORY

BOOK 01

Before the Kingdoms



Prehistory and Early Life in Assam

AxomRank

01

ASSAM HISTORY / BOOK 01 / CHAPTER 01

Reading the Deep Past

How objects, contexts and dates become a history of Assam before kingdoms.

OBJECT	CONTEXT	DATE	INTERPRETATION

A reading guide: identify the find, examine its relationships, check what the date measures, then evaluate the explanation.

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Five planned divisions. Eleven source notes. Scholarly review pending.

1.1 An object and its setting

A ground stone axe can begin a history, but its shape cannot tell the whole story. In the opening of his Sarutaru excavation report, S. N. Rao described a problem that had long confronted research in northeastern India: many stone celts had been collected from the surface or kept in households, rather than recovered through recorded excavation. Daojali Hading offered a different kind of evidence. There, celts and pottery had been found together in a stratified deposit. The important difference was not simply the number or beauty of the objects. It was the possibility of relating them to their setting.[1]

A celt is a stone implement, often ground or polished, whose form can suggest an axe or adze. Identifying that form is a useful beginning. Yet an implement picked up on an eroded slope leaves several questions unanswered. Where was it originally deposited? Was it discarded, deliberately placed, or carried there later? Which other objects belonged with it? A recorded excavation does not answer every question automatically, but it preserves relationships that an isolated find cannot supply. This is why an account of Assam before kingdoms must begin with the way knowledge is made, before asking what that knowledge permits us to say.

The archaeological record contains both things and relationships: a fragment of pottery, the sediment around it, its position beside other finds, the feature in which it lay, and the sequence of deposits above and below. An object may survive while those relationships disappear. Conversely, a modest fragment with a documented position may answer a question that a spectacular, unprovenanced object cannot. We should therefore ask two questions of every find: what is it, and what is known about where it came from?

Sarutaru provides a concrete example. In his separate account in Asian Perspectives, Rao reported three trenches, each three metres square. He described ground stone celts and potsherds within a cultural horizon extending from about 20 to 53 centimetres below the surface. The three trenches, he stated, showed similar stratigraphy and archaeological material. These observations gave the artifacts a recorded association within the excavated deposits. They did not, by themselves, supply a calendar date for the horizon.[2]

The report also shows why observation and interpretation should remain distinct. Rao recorded carbonized wood in the trenches and explained it as the result of burning vegetation during shifting cultivation. The charcoal is a reported observation; the explanation identifies a proposed activity. To evaluate that explanation, a reader would need to ask whether the charcoal's position, character and relationship to the artifacts exclude other sources of burning. Respecting the fieldworker's record does not require treating every inference as a directly observed fact.[2]

This book follows that distinction. Where an excavator reports a find, the narrative will say so. Where an author proposes a connection or a function, that interpretation will be identified. Where the evidence does not resolve a question, the gap will remain visible. The people who made and used these objects deserve a history grounded in what survives of their actions, rather than a story enlarged to fill every silence.

1.2 Layers, movement, and missing places

Stratigraphy is the study of relationships between deposits and features. It offers relative sequence: one deposit lies above another; a pit cuts through an earlier layer; material enters the pit after it has been dug. Such relationships can establish an order without establishing a year. For dating, the critical question is whether the recovered sample belongs to the event we want to understand. Material can be residual, surviving from an earlier episode, or intrusive, entering a deposit later. Its position needs an explanation, not merely a depth measurement.[3]

Consider a hypothetical pit dug into an older occupation layer. An old potsherd may become part of its fill. The sherd's manufacture predates the filling of the pit, even though it is recovered within that fill. This example is not a reconstruction of Sarutaru. It illustrates why objects found together need not all have been made together, and why depth alone cannot replace a record of how deposits formed.

An excavation report is therefore more than a catalogue. Plans and sections locate finds in a sequence; descriptions explain sediment and features; tables record material and samples. The strength of an interpretation depends partly

on whether those records allow another researcher to examine its foundations. A broad cultural label such as Neolithic cannot perform the work of a trench plan, a sample identifier or a measured date.

Surface exploration has a different value. It can reveal where archaeological material occurs and where further investigation may be worthwhile. In her survey of the Karbi Langpi valley, Nisha Rani Das described village-to-village exploration, random collection of cultural material, and comparison with assemblages from previously studied sites. She also confronted the difficulty of assigning chronology when pottery from different periods shares similar fabrics or decoration. A surface collection can identify a research problem without resolving the sequence beneath it.[4]

The distinction matters for a regional history. A distribution of finds may show that material deserves investigation across a wider landscape. It cannot automatically be read as a map of simultaneously occupied settlements. Before drawing routes of migration or exchange, we need to know whether the compared objects belong to comparable periods and whether their materials or production techniques support the proposed connection. Similarity raises a question; association and dating help test it.

Even the location of a previously excavated site can become uncertain. In his 2023 doctoral thesis, Jitendra Kumar described attempts to relocate Sarutaru and Marakdola. Earlier descriptions, map searches and conversations with local residents did not securely identify the old Sarutaru excavation spot. Marakdola was relocated with the help of menhirs described in earlier publications. New roads, factories and residential construction had altered the visible landscape.[5]

This is a history of evidence as well as a history reconstructed from evidence. A place-name may persist while a mound changes or disappears. A modern sign or a map pin is useful for orientation, but it does not independently identify an old trench. Local knowledge can guide investigation; older photographs and field records can help evaluate it. Their agreement, and their disagreements, must be recorded. Failure to relocate a trench today does not erase the earlier excavation, but it changes what can now be checked in the field.

1.3 Dating an event, not an entire people

A date becomes meaningful when we know what was measured. Radiocarbon analysis estimates an age from the carbon remaining in suitable material. Conventional radiocarbon results use BP, with the reference point fixed at 1950, and include a laboratory identifier and measurement uncertainty. They are not calendar years obtained by simple subtraction. Calibration relates the measurement to a calendar timescale because atmospheric radiocarbon has varied. Published calendar estimates need the calibration method, curve and probability level, as well as the original result.[6]

The sample and the historical question must also be connected. Charcoal near a potsherd does not necessarily date that vessel's manufacture. Wood can contain growth older than its burning, and previously deposited charcoal can enter a later context. The archaeological interpretation must establish why the sample is relevant to the activity being dated. Laboratory precision cannot restore a relationship that was never recorded.[3]

Luminescence measures a different process. In pottery, mineral grains can retain a signal related to radiation received after the relevant resetting event. Sharma and Singh's study explains its age estimate in terms of accumulated dose divided by dose rate. Their 2017 paper reported an optically stimulated luminescence, or OSL, result of **2.7 ± 0.3 ka** for Daojali Hading sample **LD1728**. Here ka expresses thousands of years. The same table reported **2.3 ± 0.2 ka** for Gawak Abri sample **LD1727**, a comparison from Meghalaya.[7]

Those results must retain their method and uncertainty. They should not be relabelled radiocarbon dates, reduced to exact years, or transferred from a Meghalaya sample to an Assam site. The Daojali estimate is evidence about the dated pottery sample. It is not a measurement of the first arrival of people in Assam, the beginning of all pottery production in the region, or the birth of a named community. Those are different questions requiring different evidence.

The paper's methods also matter. The authors worked with pottery collected during the earlier excavations, and reported that surrounding sediments were unavailable. For the dose-rate calculation, they measured uranium, thorium and potassium in the pottery and estimated the cosmic-ray contribution.

These details do not justify dismissing the result. They identify conditions that a specialist assessment or a new dating programme would need to consider. An age estimate is more useful when its assumptions remain attached to it.[8]

The comparison between a single sample and a regional history is especially important. One dated sherd cannot establish the duration of a settlement. A settlement may have been occupied before and after the sampled event; the surviving objects may represent only part of that occupation. Several samples, secure contexts and independent methods can strengthen a chronology, but agreement must be demonstrated rather than assumed.

Readers will therefore encounter dates in more than one form in this book. An excavation season dates the investigation. A conventional radiocarbon result describes a measurement. A calibrated range estimates a calendar placement with a stated probability. A luminescence age carries the study's reporting convention and uncertainty. A typological assignment compares material with other assemblages. These forms of time are related, but they are not interchangeable.

1.4 The past remembered and the past excavated

Assam's early past also reaches us through stories, sacred places and traditions of origin. Their importance should not depend on forcing them into the role of excavation records. A narrative can tell us how a community understands ancestry, authority or a landscape. A dated deposit addresses a different question: what activity left the recovered material, and when might that activity have occurred? Bringing these kinds of evidence into conversation requires first identifying what each can establish.

For this book, prehistoric evidence will not be dated by assigning a reign to a figure in an origin tradition. Nor will an archaeological object be attached to a named figure merely because a story is associated with the same locality. Such a connection would need an argument based on identifiable sources and their dates. The next volume, devoted to mythological Assam, will examine narratives on their own textual and cultural terms. That editorial arrangement does not assert that a precisely dated mythological age follows the archaeological sequence.

Contemporary traditions also require care. Rao's 1977 article sought to understand continuity through archaeology, ethnography and language. It compared present practices with archaeological forms, but framed communities through categories and a hierarchy of cultural development that this book does not adopt. His record of excavated artifacts can be consulted without accepting that living people preserve an unchanged prehistoric way of life.[9]

A resemblance between an old tool and a later implement may suggest a useful comparison of working movements or manufacture. It does not, by itself, identify the ancient toolmaker's language, ancestry or social institutions. The comparison also needs dates: when was the contemporary practice observed, by whom, and under what conditions? To leave those questions unasked would turn living communities into illustrations of somebody else's chronology.

Respectful historical writing keeps the makers of ancient objects and the people of the present in view without collapsing them into one timeless population. Community accounts can help locate places and identify the meanings of objects encountered today. Their contribution deserves attribution. Archaeological claims about earlier deposits still need their own contexts and tests. Neither body of knowledge becomes stronger when its limits are concealed.

1.5 From field record to readable history

The life of archaeological evidence does not end when an object leaves the ground. Sharma and Singh's work with pottery collected in earlier excavations demonstrates the continuing research value of retained material. It also makes the connection between the object and its records indispensable. A later analysis needs to know what was saved, which sample it represents and what information survives about its recovery.[10]

A museum object is consequently more useful to a historian when its catalogue, accession history and excavation documentation can be traced. A display label may give a concise identification, but a substantial historical claim needs the underlying record. Photographs reveal visible form; drawings can

make edges or decoration easier to compare; neither supplies an excavation context that was never documented. The responsible reconstruction moves between object, record and published interpretation, checking what each actually contributes.

Sometimes the records disagree. Rao's Man and Environment report gives 1967-73 for the Sarutaru work, whereas his Asian Perspectives article describes the recent excavations at the two sites as conducted in 1971-74. These statements should be preserved as a discrepancy in the reported fieldwork chronology until the season records resolve it. The dates of modern investigation must not be confused with the age of the deposits.[11]

Repeated publication also needs attention. Two accounts by the same excavator can supply different details, but repetition does not make their shared observation independent confirmation. A later summary may help find an earlier report; it should not replace that report when the question concerns the original trench or sample. Citations should allow a reader to return to the relevant page, table or section, rather than merely recognize a familiar author's name.

The same discipline applies to images. A photograph of a jar records its visible appearance at the time of photography. A modern illustration can help a reader imagine scale or texture, but invented details cannot be used as evidence. The cover of this book is an artistic composition. Its arrangement does not establish that the depicted forms belonged to one community, one settlement or one period.

The chapters that follow begin with landscapes and human traces, then consider sites, food, crafts, connections and social memory. Their order is a route through questions, not a claim that every part of Assam passed through identical stages at the same time. Each site must carry its own evidence; each date must retain its context. Before kingdoms can be narrated, the surviving actions of earlier people must be read with care. That care makes room for a richer history: one that can explain what is known, show why it is known, and remain open to what the next excavation may change.

Source notes

Page and table references identify the passages used. Links open the original reports or institutional sources.

1. S. N. Rao, "Excavations at Sarutaru: A Neolithic Site in Assam," Man and Environment 1 (1977), pp. 39-43, especially p. 39 (PDF p. 48). The opening paragraph distinguishes surface and household collections from the stratified association at Daojali Hading. Report scan.

2. S. N. Rao, "Continuity and Survival of Neolithic Traditions in Northeastern India," Asian Perspectives 20, no. 2 (1977), pp. 191-205, especially p. 195 and fig. 2; pottery description p. 198. The charcoal's association with shifting cultivation is Rao's interpretation. Full article.

3. Alex Bayliss and Peter Marshall, Radiocarbon Dating and Chronological Modelling: Guidelines and Best Practice (London: Historic England, 2022), section 3.2.2, "Archaeological criteria for identifying suitable samples," and section 3.2.3, "Scientific criteria for identifying suitable samples." The guidance concerns archaeological method; it does not provide dates for Assam. Relevant chapter. Accessed 11 October 2026.

4. Nisha Rani Das, "Preliminary Explorations in the Karbi Langpi Valley, Karbi Anglong District, Assam with Special Emphasis on the Ceramics," Heritage: Journal of Multidisciplinary Studies in Archaeology 7 (2019), pp. 670-678, especially pp. 670-671, "Aims and Objectives" and "Methods of Study," and pp. 676-677, discussion. Article.

5. Jitendra Kumar, Archaeology of the Digaru-Kolong River Valley with Special Emphasis on the Neolithic Period (PhD thesis, Indian Institute of Technology Guwahati, 2023), p. 41 (PDF p. 61), "Locating the site," with figs. 2.1-2.3 on pp. 42-43. The thesis reports local identification of Sarutaru/Sarutari but does not relocate the earlier excavation spot. Institutional record.

6. Bayliss and Marshall, Radiocarbon Dating and Chronological Modelling, sections 1.1, 1.3 and 1.5, on measurement, BP and calibration. Radiocarbon dating chapter. Accessed 11 October 2026.

7. Sukanya Sharma and Pankaj Singh, "Luminescence Dating of Neolithic Pottery in North East India," Current Science 113, no. 3 (2017), pp. 492-496, table 1 on p. 493 (PDF p. 2), and p. 494 on age calculation. Laboratory identifiers and uncertainties are retained as printed; no exact BCE conversion is asserted here. DOI.

8. Sharma and Singh, "Luminescence Dating," pp. 493-494, sample preparation and dose-rate discussion, including the unavailability of surrounding sediment. This chapter identifies a reported methodological condition, not a new laboratory reanalysis or a finding that the published age is invalid.

9. Rao, "Continuity and Survival," pp. 191-194, especially the geographical framework and "Ethnographic Present." The assessment of the article's cultural hierarchy and the decision not to use modern communities as unchanged prehistoric models are this book's editorial interpretation.

10. Sharma and Singh, "Luminescence Dating," p. 493, discussion of pottery collected during the 1961 and 1999 excavations. The argument about retaining the link between material and documentation is drawn from the requirements illustrated by this study.

11. Rao, "Excavations at Sarutaru," p. 39 (1967-73); Rao, "Continuity and Survival," p. 194, "Excavations" (1971-74 for the two sites). These are the published statements, not a resolved season-by-season chronology.